

Wind beneath wings

New aviary gives
eagles the space
to fly, recover

By **TONYA JAMESON**
Staff Writer

The bald eagle leans forward, ready for flight. He hops off the tree stump and onto the ground, hopelessly flapping giant black wings, spinning in a circle.

Behind him, another bald eagle squawks and a third, with only one wing, tries to fly.

The three are among six regal birds featured in the Carolina Raptor Center's new \$70,000 eagle aviary. It's the only one in the Carolinas and the largest in the Southeast, said Bill Veach, the center's executive director.

It's finished, except for landscaping, and will be dedicated April 24. The center will host an open house from 10 a.m. to 1 p.m. Saturday to give the public the opportunity to visit the new aviary and to become volunteers at the facility.

The nonprofit raptor center is a hospital for injured birds of prey — eagles, owls, hawks and falcons — which help keep the rodent population under control. Many of the birds have been shot or hit by cars. Those that survive are returned to the wild if they can hunt.

The center treats about 500 birds a year; about half are released. Others are kept in outdoor aviaries, which are scattered along the one-mile trail.

The eagle aviary is built on a

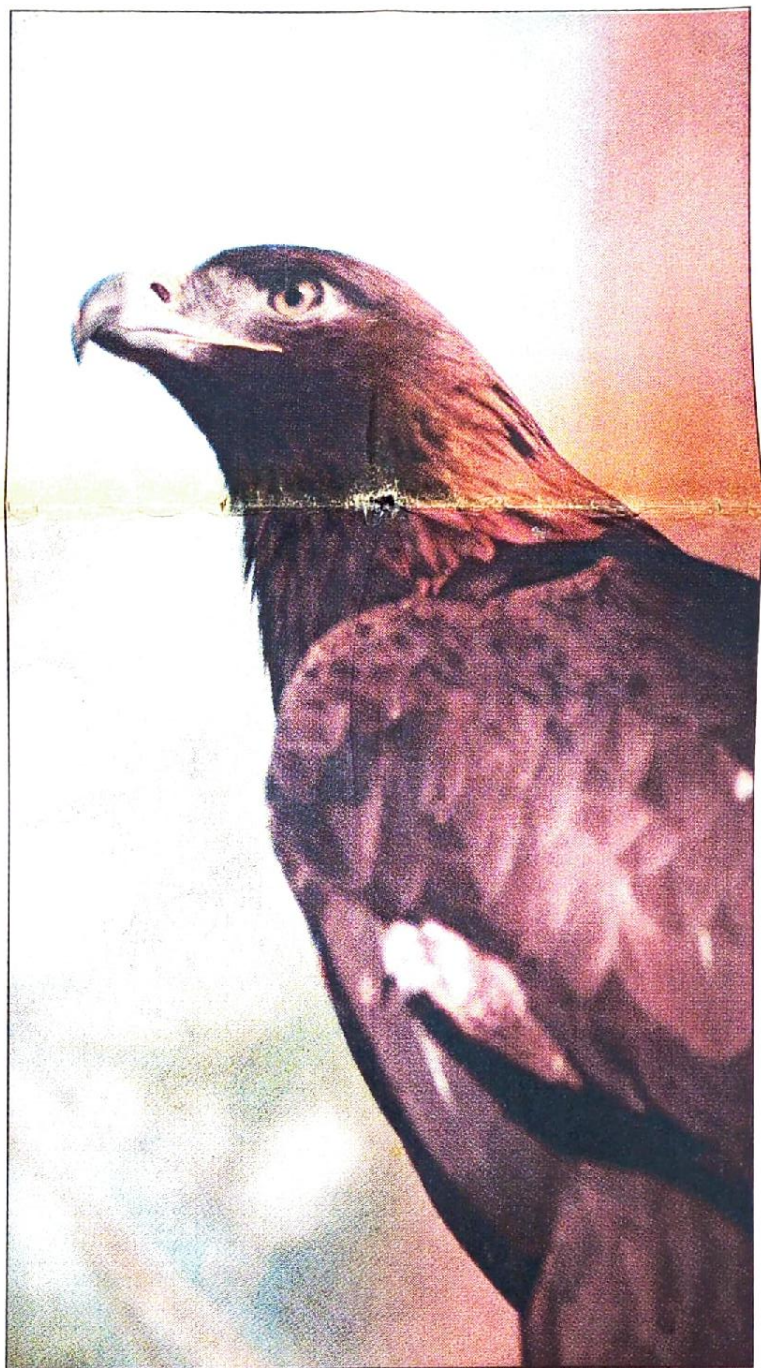
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WANT TO GO?

The open house is from 10 a.m. to 1 p.m. Saturday. It's free, but admission usually is \$4 for adults, \$2 for senior citizens and students. Children younger than 6 are free if accompanied by their parents. The center is in Latta Plantation Park at the end of Sample Road, off Beatties Ford Road.



Pioneer and Orion, two golden eagles, perch at the new eagle aviary at Carolina Raptor Center.



Photos by **STEPHANIE GRACE LIM**, Staff

Orion, one of the Carolina Raptor Center's two golden eagles, perches in the new aviary, built big enough to allow the birds to fly and foil thieves.

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RAPTOR

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new trail and is the newest addition to the center, which rests on 57 acres at Latta Plantation Park. Volunteers are excited about the new aviary, but they recall what prompted the high-tech bird cage.

In October 1993, someone crept along the mulch trail to a 250-square-foot cage. Inside sat two golden eagles, Caesar and Betsy. The intruders cut the padlock door and stole Caesar and Betsy.

~~The two birds were never found. They probably were killed~~

for their feathers, which can be worth thousands of dollars and are used in some religious ceremonies, Veach said.

The thieves also stole the center's sense of security. Pat Marcum, then executive director of the center, said eagles wouldn't be displayed on the trail until they built a secure facility.

The Betty J. and J. Stanley Livingstone Foundation provided a \$40,000 grant. A capital campaign raised \$20,000. Duke Energy donated the tall support poles; Sonitrol contributed a high-tech security system; and businesses and individuals donated labor, materials and money.

Now, the eagles have moved beyond Betsy and Caesar's old wooden shack with two perching posts. Their new home resembles a huge batting cage: It is four stories high, with cargo netting that encloses a 25,000-square-foot rectangle that's 80 feet wide.

And it comes complete with a security system that alerts the authorities to intruders.

The aviary has trees that nearly touch the top of the cargo netting. Grass, weeds and tree stumps carpet the ground. It can hold up to 12 eagles.

In the bald eagles' section sat Hali, Queen Charlotte, Sir Raleigh, and an unnamed immature eagle with an amputated wing. Hali is from Virginia; the others are from the Charlotte area.

They didn't appear to like visitors. They tried to fly around the aviary, but shattered wings prevented them from doing more than an awkward hop-run combination. Hali expressed her displeasure by constantly screeching.

In the other part of the aviary, golden eagles Pioneer and Orion ignored the ruckus and the visitors. Pioneer is blind in one eye from a gunshot wound; Orion has a broken wing. Both were brought from Florida. They perched on their posts staring at the swaying pine trees outside the aviary.

Despite their beautiful new home, Pioneer and Orion looked as if they wanted to soar beyond those trees. But thanks to encounters with humans, their flights will end where the cargo nets meet the sky.